JanGyan — Learn Without Limits

Category : Cyber Safety & Digital Security

Module 6 - Social Media Safety

Module Overview

This handbook is your complete, beginner-to-advanced guide to **Social Media Safety** — covering Instagram, WhatsApp, Facebook, and Telegram, along with two of the most common risks across all of them: fake profiles and cyberbullying. Whether you're a student, a parent, or simply someone who wants to use social media with more confidence, this handbook gives you the practical knowledge to enjoy these platforms safely.

By the end of this module, you will not need to search anywhere else to understand how to protect yourself and your family on social media.

Learning Objectives

After completing this module, you will be able to:

- Configure privacy and safety settings on Instagram, WhatsApp, Facebook, and Telegram
- Recognise the signs of a fake or impersonating profile
- Understand what cyberbullying looks like and how to respond to it
- Know your rights and the platform obligations under India's IT Rules
- Support children and family members facing online harassment
- Know exactly where and how to report harmful content or accounts in India

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Why This Topic Matters

A 2025 survey found that **37% of teenagers in India reported experiencing cyberbullying** — one of the highest rates recorded globally. At the same time, fake and impersonating profiles remain one of the most common tools used for scams, harassment, and misinformation across every major platform.

> *Reality Check: Social media platforms operating in India are legally required to acknowledge user complaints within 24 hours and resolve them within 15 days — yet most cyberbullying incidents are never formally reported at all, leaving victims to face it alone.*

Social media connects billions of people — but the same openness that makes it valuable also creates space for impersonation and harassment. Understanding how each platform works, how to spot a fake account, and how to respond to bullying turns social media from a source of anxiety into a space you can navigate with confidence.

Introduction

Social media safety means understanding how to control your privacy, verify who you're really interacting with, and respond appropriately when something goes wrong — across every platform you use.

This module focuses on four platforms widely used in India, plus two risks that appear on all of them:

- **Instagram** — photo/video sharing, Stories, Reels, and direct messaging
- **WhatsApp** — private messaging, group chats, and status updates
- **Facebook** — profiles, groups, pages, and marketplace
- **Telegram** — messaging and large public/private channels and groups
- **Fake Profiles** — accounts impersonating real people, brands, or entirely fabricated identities
- **Cyberbullying** — using digital platforms to harass, humiliate, or threaten another person

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Fundamental Concepts

Public vs Private Content

Setting	What It Means
Public Profile	Anyone, including strangers, can view your posts and profile details
Private Profile	Only approved followers/contacts can view your posts and activity
Public Group/Channel	Anyone can join or view content, often without admin approval

Types of Fake Profiles

Type	Purpose
Impersonation Account	Copies a real person's name/photos to deceive their contacts
Catfish Account	A fabricated identity used to build a fake relationship, often for emotional or financial manipulation
Bot/Spam Account	Automated or low-effort accounts used to spread scams, spam, or fake engagement
Brand/Celebrity Impersonation	Fake accounts posing as companies or public figures, often for scams or misinformation

What Counts as Cyberbullying

Cyberbullying includes repeated harassment, threats, humiliation, exclusion, spreading rumours, or sharing someone's private content without consent, carried out through digital platforms. It is rarely a single message — it is typically a **pattern** of behaviour intended to distress or control someone.

Complete Detailed Explanation

Part A — Platform-by-Platform Safety

Instagram
- Set your account to Private so only approved followers see your posts and Stories
- Turn off precise location tagging on posts
- Use "Restrict" or "Block" for unwanted accounts, and turn on comment/message filtering for offensive words
- Review who can message you directly under Privacy settings

WhatsApp
- Control who sees your last seen, profile photo, and status under Settings → Privacy
- Enable two-step verification for extra account security
- Be cautious of unknown numbers in groups — anyone can add you unless you restrict group invites
- Use "Report" and "Block" for unwanted individual or group contacts

Facebook
- Review "Who can see your future posts" and limit past post visibility
- Regularly check the "Apps and Websites" section to remove third-party access you no longer use
- Be selective about accepting friend requests from unfamiliar accounts
- Use privacy checkup tools to review your overall exposure

Telegram
- Set who can see your phone number and add you to groups under Privacy & Security settings
- Be cautious in large public groups/channels, which often have minimal moderation
- Avoid clicking links shared in unfamiliar channels or groups
- Use "Report" for spam, scams, or abusive content within chats

Part B — Spotting and Handling Fake Profiles

Common signs of a fake profile:

- Very few posts, mostly recent, with an unusually high follower/following ratio
- Photos that appear only recently uploaded despite claiming an old account
- Urgent requests for money, gifts, or personal information soon after connecting
- Refusal or excuses to video call or meet, despite claiming a close relationship
- Spelling/grammar inconsistent with the claimed identity or background

What to do: Do not engage further with suspicious requests, use the platform's built-in "Report" function, and inform friends/family if an account is impersonating you or someone you know.

Part C — Understanding Cyberbullying

Cyberbullying can include repeated hurtful comments, exclusion from group chats, spreading rumours, impersonation to embarrass someone, or sharing private images/information without consent. It often continues beyond school or work hours, making it feel inescapable for victims.

Why it matters: Cyberbullying can cause serious emotional distress, anxiety, and withdrawal — and its effects are not "just online," they carry into daily life and mental wellbeing.

Responding to cyberbullying:

- Do not respond in anger or engage with the bully directly
- Save evidence — screenshots, timestamps, usernames — before blocking or reporting

- Use the platform's official reporting tools for harassment
- Involve a trusted adult, teacher, or platform/legal authority, especially for serious or repeated incidents
- Report serious threats or exploitation to the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal

If cyberbullying involves threats, sharing of private images without consent, or targets a child, treat it as a serious matter requiring immediate reporting to the platform and to the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal — not something to resolve informally.

Important Terminologies

Term	Simple Meaning
Cyberbullying	Using digital platforms to repeatedly harass, humiliate, or threaten someone
Catfishing	Creating a fake online identity to deceive someone, often emotionally or financially
Impersonation	Creating a fake account using someone else's name or photos
Doxxing	Publicly revealing someone's private information without consent
Trolling	Deliberately posting inflammatory or upsetting content to provoke reactions
Grievance Officer	A platform representative required to acknowledge and resolve user complaints
Significant Social Media Intermediary (SSMI)	A platform meeting a government-notified user threshold, facing extra compliance obligations

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Step-by-Step Understanding

How to Lock Down Your Social Media Privacy

1. Set your account to Private on every platform where that option exists
2. Review and limit who can message you directly
3. Turn off precise location sharing on posts and stories
4. Review and remove old third-party app access to your accounts
5. Regularly review your follower/friend list for unfamiliar accounts

How to Report a Fake Profile or Cyberbullying Content

1. Take screenshots as evidence before blocking or reporting
2. Use the platform's built-in "Report" feature, selecting the correct category (impersonation, harassment, etc.)
3. Block the account to stop further contact
4. Inform a trusted adult, employer, or authority if the situation is serious
5. File a complaint at cybercrime.gov.in for threats, exploitation, or repeated targeted harassment

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Real-Life Indian Examples

(General, widely recognised patterns described for educational awareness.)

- **Impersonation-Based Scams:** Fake profiles copying real users' photos and names to message their friends and family asking for urgent money transfers have been repeatedly flagged by Indian cyber cells as a recurring fraud pattern.
- **School and College Cyberbullying Cases:** Indian schools and colleges have increasingly reported cases of students facing harassment through group chats and anonymous accounts, prompting several institutions to introduce digital-wellbeing and cyberbullying-reporting programmes.
- **Fake Celebrity/Brand Accounts:** Impersonation accounts posing as celebrities or well-known brands promising fake giveaways or investment opportunities remain a persistent and widely reported issue across Indian social media.

Practical Scenarios

Scenario 1: A profile using your friend's name and photos messages you asking to borrow money urgently.
Verify directly with your friend through another channel (a call, not the same account) before responding — this is a classic impersonation scam.

Scenario 2: Your child is being repeatedly excluded and mocked in a class WhatsApp group.
This is cyberbullying. Save evidence, involve the school and a trusted adult, and use the platform's reporting tools for the group/individuals involved.

Scenario 3: Someone you've never met online insists on a relationship but always has an excuse to avoid video calls.
This is a common catfishing pattern. Avoid sharing money or personal details, and consider ending contact if red flags continue.

Scenario 4: An anonymous account keeps posting embarrassing comments about a coworker in a public group.
Report the account and the specific posts to the platform, and encourage the person affected to document and report the harassment formally if it continues.

Government Rules / Guidelines

- **MeitY (Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology):** Administers the IT Rules governing social media platforms operating in India.
- **National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal:** Provides a dedicated category for reporting cyberbullying and crimes against women and children, alongside general cybercrime complaints.
- **National Commission for Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR):** Addresses child-safety concerns, including online harassment and exploitation involving minors.

Laws & Policies

Law / Provision	What It Covers
IT Rules, 2021 (as amended, effective 15 November 2025)	Requires intermediaries to acknowledge complaints within 24 hours and resolve them within 15 days; mandates takedown of unlawful content within 36 hours of a valid order, and within 24 hours for complaints involving nudity or non-consensual intimate imagery
Significant Social Media Intermediary (SSMI) Obligations	Large platforms must appoint a Chief Compliance Officer, a Grievance Redressal Officer, and a nodal contact person
IT Act, 2000 — Section 66E	Punishes capturing or publishing images of a person's private area or activity without consent
IT Act, 2000 — Sections 67 / 67A	Punish publishing or transmitting obscene or sexually explicit material electronically
Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012	Provides special protection for children against sexual abuse and exploitation, including online
Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023	Covers offences like criminal intimidation, stalking, and defamation, applicable to online harassment

Important Statistics

Metric	Figure
Indian teens reporting cyberbullying (2025 survey)	37% — among the highest rates globally
Grievance acknowledgement timeline under IT Rules	Within 24 hours of complaint
Grievance resolution timeline under IT Rules	Within 15 days
Takedown timeline for court/government-ordered content	Within 36 hours
Takedown timeline for nudity/non-consensual imagery complaints	Within 24 hours

(Figures are approximate, drawn from published surveys and IT Rules notifications through 2025–2026.)

Best Practices

- Set profiles to private by default across Instagram, Facebook, and similar platforms
- Verify identity independently before trusting money or personal requests from any online contact
- Save evidence (screenshots, usernames, timestamps) before blocking or reporting
- Use each platform's official reporting tools rather than engaging directly with a bully or scammer

- Regularly review privacy settings, follower lists, and connected third-party apps
- Talk openly with children about what to do if something online feels wrong

Common Mistakes

- Accepting friend/follow requests from unfamiliar accounts without verification
- Responding angrily or engaging directly with a bully or troll
- Assuming a profile is genuine because it "looks" like someone you know
- Deleting messages/evidence before reporting an incident
- Ignoring warning signs in an online-only relationship (avoiding calls, urgent money requests)
- Staying silent about cyberbullying instead of involving a trusted adult or authority

Myths vs Facts

Myth	Fact
"Cyberbullying isn't as serious as in-person bullying"	Cyberbullying can follow a person everywhere, at any hour, and causes real emotional harm
"If an account has my friend's photos, it must be them"	Impersonation accounts commonly copy photos and details from real profiles
"Reporting a fake profile rarely does anything"	Platforms are legally required to acknowledge and act on valid complaints within set timelines under India's IT Rules
"Blocking someone online fully stops the problem"	Serious or repeated harassment often needs formal reporting, not just blocking, especially involving threats or minors
"Private accounts are completely safe from fake profiles"	Fake accounts can still send follow/message requests to private accounts — always verify before accepting

Do's and Don'ts

Do	Don't
Set your key social profiles to private	Don't leave profiles fully public without reviewing who can see them
Verify unusual requests through another channel	Don't send money or personal details based on a chat request alone
Save evidence before blocking or reporting	Don't delete messages before documenting a harassment incident
Use official in-app reporting tools	Don't engage directly or argue with a bully or scammer
Involve a trusted adult for serious incidents involving minors	Don't assume a child will resolve serious harassment alone

Safety Tips

For Everyday Use
- Review privacy settings on each platform at least every few months
- Think before accepting requests from unfamiliar accounts
- Avoid oversharing location, travel plans, or daily routines publicly

For Parents & Families
- Keep an open, non-judgmental conversation about online experiences
- Learn the reporting tools on platforms your children use
- Watch for signs of distress that may indicate online harassment

For Handling Harassment
- Document everything before blocking or reporting
- Use platform-specific reporting categories accurately (impersonation, harassment, etc.)
- Escalate to cybercrime.gov.in for serious, repeated, or threatening behaviour

For Spotting Fake Profiles
- Reverse-check unfamiliar profile photos where possible
- Be cautious of urgent emotional or financial requests from recent contacts
- Insist on a video call before trusting a long-distance online relationship

Practical Checklist

- ☐ Set key social media accounts to private
- ☐ Reviewed who can message/follow me directly
- ☐ Learned how to report impersonation and harassment on each platform I use
- ☐

Talked with family/children about safe social media habits

☐ Know to save evidence before blocking or reporting

☐ Saved the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal and 1930 helpline details

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Quick Revision Notes

- Social media safety spans privacy settings, spotting fake profiles, and responding to cyberbullying
- Fake profiles include impersonation, catfishing, and bot/spam accounts
- Cyberbullying is typically a pattern of harassment, not a single message
- IT Rules require platforms to acknowledge complaints in 24 hours, resolve in 15 days, and take down serious content (like non-consensual imagery) within 24 hours
- Always save evidence before blocking or reporting
- Serious or repeated harassment should go to cybercrime.gov.in, not just stay unresolved

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Key Takeaways

1. A profile "looking" genuine is not the same as being genuine — verify independently
2. Cyberbullying's effects are real and serious, whether or not it happens "in person"
3. Platforms have legal obligations in India to respond to valid complaints — use official reporting tools
4. Evidence matters — screenshot before you block
5. No one should have to handle serious online harassment alone

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Glossary

- **Catfishing** — Creating a fake online identity to deceive someone
- **Cyberbullying** — Repeated harassment, humiliation, or threats carried out through digital platforms
- **Doxxing** — Publicly revealing someone's private information without consent
- **Grievance Officer** — A platform representative required to handle user complaints
- **Impersonation** — Creating a fake account using someone else's identity
- **SSMI** — Significant Social Media Intermediary, a large platform with extra compliance obligations
- **Trolling** — Deliberately posting inflammatory content to provoke a reaction

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Frequently Asked Questions

1. How do I make my Instagram/Facebook account private?
Go to account Privacy settings and switch your profile visibility from Public to Private.

2. What is a fake profile?
An account created to impersonate someone, fabricate a false identity, or automate spam/scam activity.

3. How can I tell if a profile is fake?
Look for few or recent posts, unusual follower ratios, urgent money requests, and reluctance to video call.

4. What is cyberbullying?
The use of digital platforms to repeatedly harass, humiliate, exclude, or threaten someone.

5. What should I do if I'm being cyberbullied?
Save evidence, avoid engaging directly, use official reporting tools, and involve a trusted adult or authority for serious cases.

6. How quickly must platforms respond to complaints in India?
They must acknowledge complaints within 24 hours and resolve them within 15 days under India's IT Rules.

7. What is catfishing?
Creating a fake online identity to build a false relationship, often for emotional or financial manipulation.

8. Should I accept follow/friend requests from strangers?
Only after careful consideration — verify mutual connections or context before accepting.

9. What is doxxing?
Publicly revealing someone's private information, such as their address or phone number, without consent.

10. Can a private account still receive fake profile requests?
Yes — always verify before accepting any follow or message request, even on a private account.

11. What is a Grievance Officer?
A designated platform representative responsible for acknowledging and resolving user complaints.

12. What is the fastest takedown timeline under IT Rules?
24 hours, for complaints involving nudity or non-consensual intimate imagery.

13. Should I respond angrily to a troll or bully online?
No — engaging directly often escalates the situation; reporting and blocking are more effective.

14. What should parents do if their child is being cyberbullied?
Stay calm and supportive, document the harassment, involve the school if relevant, and use official reporting tools.

15. Can impersonation accounts be reported directly to the platform?
Yes — all major platforms have a specific "impersonation" reporting category.

16. Is it safe to send money to someone I've only met online?
No — verify their identity independently first, especially if the request feels urgent or emotional.

17. What law protects children from online sexual exploitation in India?
The Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012.

18. What is a Significant Social Media Intermediary (SSMI)?
A platform meeting a government-notified user threshold, facing extra obligations like appointing compliance and grievance officers.

19. Where can I report serious cyberbullying or harassment in India?
On the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (cybercrime.gov.in), which has a dedicated crime-against-women-and-children category.

20. Should I delete bullying messages immediately?
No — save screenshots and evidence first, then block or report.

21. Can a fake profile be created using my real photos?
Yes — this is common; regularly search your own name/photos online to check for impersonation.

22. Is blocking someone enough to stop serious harassment?
Not always — for serious, repeated, or threatening behaviour, formal reporting is also necessary.

Suggested Infographics, Flowcharts & Illustrations

(For JanGyan design team — placement suggestions only; no images generated here)

- **Platform privacy-settings checklist (Instagram/WhatsApp/Facebook/Telegram icons)** → within "Complete Detailed Explanation, Part A"
- **"Spot the Fake Profile" red-flags visual card** → within "Complete Detailed Explanation, Part B"
- **Flowchart: "What To Do If You're Cyberbullied"** → within "Step-by-Step Understanding"
- **IT Rules grievance-timeline visual (24hr / 15 days / 36hr / 24hr)** → within "Laws & Policies"
- **Parent-child conversation-starter card for online safety** → near "Safety Tips"

Official References

- Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, and 2025 amendments — Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY)
- National Commission for Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR) — child online-safety guidance
- Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012
- Information Technology Act, 2000 (as amended), India Code portal
- National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal — official complaint categories for cyberbullying and crimes against women/children
- Published 2025 cyberbullying survey data (multi-country comparative research)

Official Government Website Links

- National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal: **https://cybercrime.gov.in**
- MeitY: **https://www.meity.gov.in**
- National Commission for Protection of Child Rights: **https://ncpcr.gov.in**
- CERT-In: **https://www.cert-in.org.in**

- Press Information Bureau: **https://pib.gov.in**

Cybercrime Helpline (24×7, Toll-Free): 1930

Conclusion

Social media is where much of everyday life now happens — friendships, learning, business, and community. Making the most of it safely means treating every profile with a healthy dose of verification, understanding that cyberbullying is a real and serious harm, and knowing exactly which button to press and which number to call when something goes wrong.

This is only the next step in your Cyber Safety journey with JanGyan. Stay alert, stay informed, and remember: **verify the person, document the harm, and never face serious harassment alone.**

JanGyan — Learn Without Limits
Module 6 of the Cyber Safety & Digital Security Category